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South Korea crash that killed 179 raises bird-strike mystery

BOY, 3, YOUNGEST VICTIM AS 65 DEAD IDENTIFIED IN COUNTRY'S WORST AIR TRAGEDY

MUAN (SOUTH KOREA)

A bird strike was cited by authorities as the likely cause of the Jeju Air Boeing 737-800 series aircraft after the plane crashed at Muan International Airport in South Korea yesterday — the worst ever aviation disaster on South Korean soil — which flung passengers out of the plane and left it “almost completely destroyed”.

Investigators probing the cause of the accident will focus on a bird strike and also the unusual landing-gear failure in the final moments of the fateful flight that left all but two of the 181 occupants of the Boeing Co. 737 jet dead.

The accident poses several unusual mysteries, and investigators have said it's too soon to speculate what may have caused the crash. Mid-air bird strikes are rare but not entirely uncommon.

The pilot, considered an experienced captain with close to 7,000 hours of active duty, issued a mayday emergency call minutes after the control tower warned of a bird strike.

Tearful scenes

Yesterday, inside the Muan International Airport terminal, as tearful family members gathered to wait for news, an official began calling out the names of the 65 victims who had been identified, with each name triggering fresh cries of grief from waiting relatives. All

Rescue personnel work near the wreckage of a Jeju Air Boeing 737-800 series aircraft after the plane crashed at Muan International Airport in South Korea yesterday.

AFP



of the passengers were Korean apart from two Thais, with the youngest a three-year-old boy and the oldest a 78-year-old, authorities said.

One heart-wrenching screenshot of the final Kakao

Talk message exchange between a passenger and their family has been widely reported in local media. The message from the parent and passenger reads: “Wait, a bird is stuck in the wing. Unable to land now...

Should I leave a will?” It was the last message, sent at 9.01 am. Their child replies: “Why can't I make a call with you?”. It was delivered at 937am and has remained unread.

—Agencies

SEE ALSO P10

**New UAE law
to regulate
medical
products**

DUBAI

BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

Pricing and safety of medical products will be more strictly controlled under a new UAE law that imposes fines of up to Dh1 million on violators.

The UAE government yesterday enacted the Federal Decree-Law on Medical Products, Pharmacy Profession, and Pharmaceutical Establishments to enhance pharmaceutical security, streamline regulatory frameworks, and attract investments to the sector.

The law covers drugs, medical devices, dietary supplements, cosmetics, and more, addressing licensing, operations, and compliance for entities such as pharmacies, biobanks, research centres, and factories, including those in free zones.

It applies to pharmacy practitioners across the country, including free zones. It will also regulate a new national database for medical products, facilities, and biobanks.

Penalties include suspension of licenses, precautionary closures, license cancellations, and fines up to Dh1 million for establishments and Dh500,000 for practitioners.

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